

BEST CEOs

ALAKH PANDEY
START-UP OF THE YEAR

EDTECH EDGE

Alakh Pandey defies start-up clichés—no jargon, no hype—to build a successful edtech company

BY **PALAK AGARWAL**

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PHYSICSWALLAH (PW), the edtech unicorn founded by Alakh Pandey, is gearing up to go public this year. In a sector that has been gripped by scepticism, Pandey has steered PW to a valuation of \$3.7 billion, surpassing rivals like Unacademy (\$3.4 billion) and Vedantu (\$912 million), according to Tracxn. Yet, for Pandey, the journey is not just about the numbers. “I am a teacher first,” he says, preferring the role over that of Co-founder and CEO.

Unlike many founders, Pandey dismisses the idea of aggressive acquisitions, instead framing his company’s expansion as a series of partnerships. PW has strategically integrated platforms like Kerala-based Xylem Learning and Jodhpur-based Utkarsh Classes. “This is

a teacher’s world, and it runs on emotions,” he tells *BT*. “I do not use the term ‘acquisition.’”

PW started in 2016 as a YouTube channel where Pandey provided free lessons. Monetisation was not a concern until 2020, when he launched the PhysicsWallah app, charging students ₹1,000 for live classes. What followed was an unexpected surge—35,000 students signed up, overwhelming the platform and causing the app to crash.

“The app failed not just on the first day, but second, third, and so on. No edtech company had ever seen such a massive influx of students for a single live class—unless it was celebrity-led,” Pandey recalls. The technical failure left him devastated. He took to YouTube, writing a heartfelt community post apologising to students and admitting he had made a mistake.

After that setback, Pandey was determined to refund every student. However, what happened next was unexpected. Instead of withdrawing, students and their families rallied behind him, encouraging him to continue.

That episode was a turning point for the edtech start-up. Today, PW has an audience of nearly 50 million students across more than 100 YouTube channels, with five million enrolled in

